Design Principles in Our Low-Fi Prototypes

ENSE 271 · Group B · Activity 1
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- Jacob: main site home page
- Mohammed: research site home, publications and menus (3 pages)
- Aubin: research site home page
- Jesse: main site home page and research site home page

1 Affordances and signifiers

What it means: An affordance is what a person can do with something. A signifier is the visible cue that shows them they can do it.

Where it is in our sketches:

- Aubin: "Explore projects" and "Search the library" are drawn as rounded buttons, project cards end in "View project →", and links that leave the site carry a ↗.
- Mohammed: the featured section has < and > arrows and dots, so visitors can tell it moves and how many items there are.
- Jacob: the search box has a magnifier icon.

Why it helps: Erin's pain point was "hot link icons" on the current site. In our sketches, anything that looks clickable leads somewhere.

2 Gestalt: similarity and proximity

What it means: People see items that look alike, or sit close together, as one group.

Where it is in our sketches:

- Mohammed: projects are three cards of the same size (P1, P2, P3), and publications are four matching cards.
- Aubin: three equal boxes for the impact numbers, and library rows tagged "Article" or "Report".
- Jacob: three equal blocks for News and Events, Support and Services, and Education and Research.
- Jesse: each section (Projects, Publications, Blog, Affiliates) has its own panel.

Why it helps: Visitors can scan the page instead of reading all of it. This answers the client's feedback that the current research page is text heavy.

3 Feedback and the gulfs of execution and evaluation

What it means: The gulf of execution is working out what you can do. The gulf of evaluation is working out what happened and where you are. Good feedback closes both.

Where it is in our sketches:

- Mohammed: on the publications page, "Publications" is boxed in the menu, so visitors know which page they are on. The search box says "Search by keyword, term, field etc." so they know what to type.
- Aubin: project cards show "Current 2025-2027" or "Completed 2023-2024", so the state of each project is clear at a glance.
- Jacob: "Recent" and "Category" options sit next to the search box.

Why it helps: Researchers and students can find a paper and tell where they are without guessing.

4 End-to-end experience, not features

What it means: Design for the whole journey a person takes, not for single features on their own.

Where it is in our sketches:

- Aubin: every research page has a "← APSS main site" bar at the top and a "Need help now?" footer with needle exchange hours, phone and a link to report a needle.
- Jesse: the research home ends with links to our affiliate sites and to contact details on the main APSS site. His main site sketch puts "Get Involved" at the bottom, where engaged readers end up.

Why it helps: Our North Star customer, someone affected by HIV or hepatitis C, may land on the research site by accident. They are still one click from help. Other visitors get a clear next step at the end of the page.